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Paul Fein

The return of World No. 1 Jannik Sinner to a hero's welcome at his home tournament in Rome this month heightened the excitement for this season's second Grand Slam and its only Major on clay.

This is only the second French Open without the retired Rafael Nadal since the King of Clay took his first crown there in 2005, and intriguing questions abound. How much will Sinner's three-month absence from competition affect his match toughness — especially his shot selection and ability to win big points?

Even though Sinner was inadvertently contaminated when his physiotherapist used a banned substance (the steroid Clostebol) on his own hand before subsequently treating the Italian with it, will other players still regard him with the same respect and cordiality? Which players have improved most since the 23-year-old Italian captured the Australian Open for his third Grand Slam title in January?

Will Carlos Alcaraz, if he defends his title, begin to be compared to the incomparable Rafael Nadal, whose 14 Roland Garros crowns ranks as one of the most unbreakable records in tennis? And if Sinner wins his first Major on clay — historically his weakest surface — could he go on to triumph at Wimbledon and the US Open to achieve the rare feat of a calendar Grand Slam, last accomplished by a man in 1969?

Let's size up the field and identify the leading contenders, the dark horses, and the likely champion.

Ice cool: Jannik Sinner thrives on big games and points, and is expected to reach the final. REUTERS

ROAR IN GARROS

Jannik Sinner and Carlos Alcaraz enter as **strong favourites** in the men's draw of the French Open, while Aryna Sabalenka heads a wide-open field in the women's competition.